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anyway. I think many top athletes are like that — weak qualifiers and great final performers.

That's something I've found over time, talking to all these javelin champions, long jumpers, high jumpers, and so on — we tend to spare our power and mental energy in qualifications. We save our focus for when it really matters, so qualifying can often be a bit tough for us.

Over the years, I've started using qualifications to test javelins, run-up

angles, and get a sense of how I'm feeling. So even though I only qualified at the end, I was never super nervous in the Rio qualifications. Still, I know I gave people back home — and my fans — a really hard time.

In fact, you weren't even in the gold medal position in the final before your last throw. Were you nervous before that sixth throw?

I wasn't looking at the other throwers in the final. I was just focusing on my individual control, going from throw to throw. I was in this state where I was simply aware of where I was and just sticking to the game plan. There were no overwhelming emotions or anything — I wasn't really nervous. Before the final throw, I could see on the board that I was in the silver medal position. It was possible that someone else could have overtaken me, but that day was really hot and we had some bad wind blowing towards us, so I wasn't expecting the others to land a great throw. When I got my chance, I just stuck to my plan — which turned out to be a good idea.

What was it like when you actually won?

At first, it just seemed to me that winning the Olympics was simply another meet in my season — even if it was an important tournament. I don't think I understood right away what it meant to actually win the Olympics. It actually took a few weeks for me to realise what I had accomplished. It didn't really strike me during the competition, and I

think that was because I was just exhausted — both from the athletic performance and from all the emotions I was feeling. Sure, I realised I'd won the Olympics, but it took more time — and possibly returning home to Germany — to understand what a big thing it was to be an Olympic champion.

How did the Olympics change your life?

As soon as you're an Olympic winner, the power of your voice starts to rise and you can achieve so much more. Your footprint gets bigger, of course, but your obligations grow too. People expect more from you. There are a lot of good things, but challenges come with it. Even so, I wouldn't trade it for anything. It's the best thing that ever happened to me.

Where do you keep your Olympic medal?

It's not mounted on a display or anything, because I try to keep my home life somewhat separate from my sports career. At the end of the day, sport is still something like a job. And I also want to get away from my job a bit, even though I love it very much. My Olympic gold is in my wardrobe with my clothes. I don't bring it out often — usually only when other people ask if they can take a picture with it. But there are times when I take it out for myself — when I feel the need for a bit of motivation. The last time I took it out was two years ago. I was struggling with a lot of issues, with injury and all that, and I wanted to feel some of the old emotions once again.

You're now a family man and the father of a young boy. Does your Olympic medal mean more to him?

My son is still really young. He doesn't care much about the medal, but he loves the javelins a lot more. Sometimes he comes with me to training and wants to do everything I do. He wants to lift the bars. He wants to throw the balls. He's a kid — he just wants to play. He does know the medal is something valuable, but